Note: style : compressed essayistic clarity / Peter Turchin / Isaiah Berlin / Toynbee

1. The Instability of Satisfaction

> Human satisfaction has a strange property: it fades quickly.

> The hedonic treadmill is not just a psychological curiosity. Over centuries, entire civilisations developed cultural systems designed to manage it.

> Humans adapt quickly to improvements in their circumstances. A promotion, a successful project, a new home—each briefly changes how the world feels. Then the change fades, expectations reset, and attention shifts to the next goal.

> Long before psychology named this process, philosophers had already noticed it. Pleasure fades, success loses intensity, and desire quickly renews itself.

> Some traditions responded by reducing desire. Buddhist thinkers argued that suffering arises from craving; freedom lies in loosening attachment. Epicurus similarly concluded that tranquility comes not from acquiring more but from wanting less.

> Other traditions tried to reconcile ambition with stability. Aristotle believed fulfillment came from excellence rather than pleasure. The Bhagavad Gita encouraged action without attachment to results.
>
> These ideas differ in tone, but they respond to the same observation: happiness is unstable.

> Yet philosophy alone was never the full answer. Entire civilisations eventually confronted the same psychological problem, and their solutions were not merely individual practices but social systems. Religions, moral codes, and cultural ideals all helped people interpret success, failure, suffering, and ambition in ways that made life feel meaningful despite the fading of satisfaction.

**2. From Philosophers to Civilisations

Individual philosophers can offer powerful insights into the human condition, but they rarely stand alone. Behind every thinker lies a cultural world that shaped the questions they asked and the answers that seemed plausible.

Aristotle’s vision of human flourishing reflects the social world of the Greek city-state. Confucius’s emphasis on harmony and ritual emerged from centuries of political disorder in ancient China. The Buddha’s diagnosis of suffering was formed in a civilisation deeply preoccupied with cycles of birth and rebirth.

Philosophers often appear as solitary figures, but in reality they are the most articulate voices of larger cultural conversations.

Civilisations, over long stretches of history, accumulate shared intuitions about suffering, success, duty, and meaning. These intuitions are reinforced through religion, social institutions, stories, and everyday practices. They form coherent ways of interpreting the human predicament.

Seen from this angle, philosophy becomes less a collection of individual theories and more a distillation of civilisational experience.

This shift in perspective matters for our problem. The hedonic treadmill is not something any single thinker discovered. It is a pattern entire cultures noticed repeatedly.

And rather than converging on one solution, civilisations developed different ways of living with it.

The following sections examine several of these civilisational strategies.

3. Civilisations Under Pressure

The hedonic treadmill is a universal psychological constraint. Human beings adapt quickly to improvement, and satisfaction fades soon after it is achieved. Yet the ways societies respond to this instability vary dramatically. The deepest differences appear not at the level of individuals, but at the level of civilisations.

Ideas about the purpose of life rarely emerge in abstraction. They crystallise under pressure. Repeated historical shocks—war, invasion, ecological constraint, political collapse, or sudden abundance—force societies to confront the fragility of fortune and the unreliability of pleasure. Over time, cultures absorb these experiences and distil them into enduring intuitions about how life should be lived.

Philosophers give these intuitions their most articulate expression. Aristotle speaks of excellence, the Bhagavad Gita of detached action, Confucius of ritual order, Nietzsche of amor fati. But such ideas do not arise in isolation. They emerge from particular historical environments that repeatedly confront human beings with the same forms of instability.

When a civilisation experiences similar crises across generations, its responses gradually harden into cultural frameworks. Religions, ethical traditions, social norms, and everyday practices begin to encode shared answers to fundamental questions: What survives when fortune disappears? Where should meaning reside if pleasure proves unreliable? How should one live in a world where success cannot be trusted to endure?

These frameworks function as large-scale psychological strategies. They channel ambition, interpret suffering, and stabilise expectations. In doing so, they allow societies to organise life around something more durable than fluctuating satisfaction.

Different historical pressures produce different solutions. Societies exposed to repeated political collapse may elevate mastery and excellence. Civilisations shaped by invasion and cosmological cycles may emphasise detachment from outcomes. Cultures forged through social disintegration may prioritise order and harmony. Others anchor meaning in duty, transcendence, or endurance.

The following sections examine several such responses. Each represents not merely a philosophy, but a civilisational strategy: a way of organising life in the shadow of the same underlying discovery—that happiness fades, and meaning must therefore be built elsewhere.

Case Studies: Civilisational Responses

The Mediterranean World — Excellence

Trauma

The classical Mediterranean world was marked by visible cycles of rise and collapse. City-states flourished, dominated their neighbours, and then fell in war, plague, or political upheaval. The Peloponnesian War, the collapse of Athenian democracy, and the constant rivalry between poleis made instability impossible to ignore.

Philosophy

Aristotle's answer was *arete*—excellence. If fortune is unreliable, the good life must be anchored in the cultivation of human capacities rather than in external success.

Strategy

Meaning lies in mastery: the disciplined pursuit of skill, virtue, and flourishing. Wealth may vanish, but the cultivated mind and the practiced craft endure longer than fortune.

Blind Spot

Excellence presupposes a degree of stability and leisure. A philosophy centred on cultivation can become aristocratic, overlooking those whose circumstances leave little space for refinement.

Indian Civilisation — Detachment

Trauma

The Indian subcontinent experienced repeated waves of conquest and political upheaval across millennia, alongside recurrent famine and a deeply stratified social order. At the same

time, Indian cosmology framed existence itself as cyclical—birth, death, and rebirth without clear final resolution.

Philosophy

Texts such as the *Bhagavad Gita* responded by redefining the relationship between action and outcome. One must act fully in accordance with duty, yet relinquish attachment to results.

Strategy

The psychological move is detachment. Action continues, but expectation dissolves. By severing the emotional link between effort and reward, the hedonic treadmill loses its mechanism.

Blind Spot

Detachment can drift into resignation. A philosophy that neutralises disappointment may also reduce urgency in confronting injustice or structural suffering.

Northern Europe — Will

Trauma

In Northern Europe the crisis was not merely political but metaphysical. The Reformation shattered religious unity, the Thirty Years' War devastated societies, and the Enlightenment gradually eroded the theological framework that had structured meaning for centuries.

Philosophy

By the nineteenth century Nietzsche could state the problem directly: the collapse of inherited meaning structures had left individuals alone with the task of creating value.

Strategy

Meaning becomes an act of will. One must affirm life entirely—*amor fati*—and construct a life worth repeating despite the absence of transcendent guarantees.

Blind Spot

The psychological demands are extreme. A framework centred on individual will can slide into isolation, nihilism, or domination when shared moral structures weaken.

East Asian Civilisation — Harmony

Trauma

The Chinese philosophical tradition emerged from the prolonged disorder of the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods—centuries of warfare, dynastic collapse, and social fragmentation.

Philosophy

Confucius responded not by pursuing inner satisfaction but by restoring social order through ritual, hierarchy, and cultivated roles.

Strategy

Meaning resides in the maintenance of harmony. The individual finds stability not through personal happiness but through correct participation in the social fabric.

Blind Spot

Harmony can become conformity. Systems designed to preserve order may suppress dissent, creativity, and the expression of individual suffering.

Islamic Civilisation — Transcendence

Trauma

Islamic civilisation experienced an unusual historical arc: rapid expansion from austere desert origins into a vast and wealthy empire within a few generations. This sudden abundance generated its own spiritual crisis.

Philosophy

Thinkers such as Al-Ghazali responded by redirecting desire toward the divine. Finite goods inevitably disappoint; only the infinite can absorb the full intensity of human longing.

Strategy

Rather than suppress desire, the tradition reorients it. The energy that fuels the hedonic treadmill is redirected toward transcendence.

Blind Spot

This solution depends on genuine belief. Where transcendent faith weakens, the framework loses its psychological anchor.

Jewish Civilisation — Obligation

Trauma

Few traditions have experienced such repeated cycles of destruction and reconstruction: the loss of the First and Second Temples, expulsions, pogroms, and ultimately the Holocaust. Each rebuilding was shadowed by the expectation that it might again be destroyed.

Philosophy

Texts such as Ecclesiastes confront the instability of worldly achievement directly. Rabbinic tradition responds by grounding meaning in law, obligation, and repair rather than permanence.

Strategy

Meaning resides in responsibility. One builds, teaches, repairs, and preserves not because success is guaranteed, but because the work itself is binding.

Blind Spot

Obligation without resolution can produce chronic urgency. The drive to repair the world may itself become a permanent psychological burden.

Polynesian Civilisation — Embedded Identity

Trauma

Polynesian societies emerged from the extraordinary feat of long-distance navigation across the Pacific, followed by life on small islands with extremely limited ecological margins.

Philosophy

Identity was therefore constructed not as an autonomous individual self but as a node within a lineage linking ancestors, land, sea, and descendants.

Strategy

By dissolving the sharply bounded individual, the culture removes the psychological agent most susceptible to hedonic comparison. Meaning resides in belonging rather than acquisition.

Blind Spot

Such systems function best in small, place-bound communities. They scale poorly in large, mobile, modern societies.

Comparative Summary of Civilisational Responses

Civilisation	Recurring Historical Pressure	Psychological Strategy	Where Meaning Is Anchored	Structural Blind Spot
Mediterranean	Cycles of political rise and collapse among competing city-states	Pursuit of **excellence** (*arete*)	Mastery, virtue, cultivated skill	Requires stability and leisure; can become aristocratic
Indian	Cyclical suffering, invasions, and cosmology of endless rebirth	**Detachment from outcomes**	Duty performed without attachment to results	May drift into passivity or acceptance of injustice
Northern European	Sequential collapse of religious and metaphysical frameworks	**Assertion of individual will**	Self-created values and affirmation of fate	Psychological extremity; risk of nihilism or isolation
East Asian	Prolonged social disorder and need for collective coordination	**Harmony through social roles**	Ritual, hierarchy, and relational duty	Conformity may suppress dissent and individuality
Islamic	Rapid expansion from austerity to imperial abundance	**Redirection of desire toward transcendence**	Devotion to the divine as infinite object of desire	Dependent on sustained religious belief
Jewish	Repeated destruction followed by rebuilding across centuries	**Obligation and repair**	Law, responsibility, and covenantal duty	Persistent urgency; difficulty finding rest
Polynesian	Extreme ecological constraint in isolated island environments	**Embedded identity within lineage and land**	Belonging to ancestry, place, and community	Difficult to scale beyond small, place-bound societies

The Psychological Strategies Behind Civilisational Responses

If the hedonic treadmill arises from the interaction of desire, expectation, identity, and meaning, then civilisations tend to stabilise life by modifying one of these variables. Beneath

their cultural differences, most traditions can be understood as variations of a small number of psychological strategies.

Strategy Type	What Is Changed	Core Psychological Move	Civilisational Expressions	Strength	Stru Risk
Desire Reduction	Desire itself	Reduce the intensity of wanting	Indian traditions, Buddhism	Inner calm, emotional stability	Pass redu urge char
Expectation Detachment	Relationship between effort and outcome	Act fully but relinquish attachment to results	Stoicism, Bhagavad Gita	Freedom from disappointment	Can wea moti or p enga
Meaning Relocation	Where meaning resides	Anchor life in something more durable than pleasure	Greek excellence, Confucian duty, Islamic devotion	Provides strong purpose and direction	Can rigid struc or el fram
Identity Transformation	The self that experiences desire	Redefine or dissolve the individual self	Polynesian lineage identity, some Eastern traditions	Reduces comparison and status competition	Diffi sust large mob soci
Affirm the treadmill itself			Jewish obligation,		

5. What Each Civilisation Is Trying to Protect

Looking across these traditions side by side reveals a deeper pattern. Civilisations are not simply offering different techniques for happiness. They are protecting against different dangers.

Every culture begins with a particular fear about the human condition. From that fear emerges a strategy for organising life so that meaning remains possible even when pleasure fades.

Some societies fear chaos. Others fear endless craving, spiritual emptiness, exile, or the collapse of moral order. Their philosophies are attempts to stabilise life against these threats.

Seen this way, civilisational wisdom does not primarily disagree about what makes people happy. It disagrees about what must be prevented at all costs.

The table below summarises these protective logics. Each tradition identifies a vulnerability in human life and builds its meaning system around guarding against it.

Tradition	Civilisational Fear	Cultural Response	What It Protects
Mediterranean	chaos destroying beauty	cultivate excellence and balanced flourishing	human flourishing
Indian	endless craving and attachment	detach from desire	inner freedom
Northern European	meaninglessness after the collapse of tradition	create meaning through will and action	individual strength
Russian	a world without spiritual depth	redeem suffering through moral struggle	moral depth
East Asian	social disorder and fragmentation	harmonise roles and relationships	social harmony
Jewish	exile, loss, and historical rupture	sustain identity through responsibility and repair	ethical responsibility and continuity
Islamic	spiritual emptiness and moral disorientation	orient desire toward God	spiritual orientation
Polynesian	separation from nature and community	dissolve the individual into the living world	ecological belonging

6. Conclusion: Dancing With the Wheel

The hedonic treadmill can feel like a discouraging discovery.

If satisfaction fades, if achievements quickly become normal, if pleasure never stabilises for long, then the pursuit of happiness begins to look strangely fragile. Many people encounter this realization gradually, often after years of striving. What once appeared to be the final milestone reveals itself as only another step.

But civilisations have lived with this knowledge for a very long time.

Long before psychologists named the phenomenon, cultures across the world noticed the same pattern. Pleasure fades. Success loses its intensity. Desire quietly resets and begins moving again.

Rather than treating this as a flaw in life, they built ways of living around it.

Some traditions concluded that the solution was to loosen the grip of desire itself. Others decided that meaning must be created through excellence, courage, responsibility, or spiritual orientation. Some anchored life in social harmony, others in moral struggle, and still others in a deep sense of belonging within nature.

What they all shared was a refusal to treat happiness as the central foundation of a life.

The hedonic treadmill does not disappear. But it stops being the main reference point.

Instead, life becomes organised around something more durable: mastery, duty, transcendence, community, depth, or inner freedom.

Seen from this perspective, the diversity of civilisational wisdom begins to look less like disagreement and more like **a map of human experimentation**. Different cultures explored different ways of stabilising meaning in a world where pleasure inevitably fades.

No single tradition solves the problem completely. Each illuminates part of the landscape while leaving other areas less developed. Yet taken together they reveal something encouraging.

Human beings have never relied solely on happiness to justify their lives.

They have learned to build structures of meaning that remain standing even when the emotional weather changes.

The image of the treadmill therefore deserves a small correction.

We do not escape the wheel. Human desire continues to move, and new goals will always appear on the horizon. But once we understand the pattern, the relationship to it can change.

The person who studies the map of civilisational wisdom does not chase the next moment of satisfaction with the same desperation. Instead, he begins to shape his life around deeper principles—principles that remain meaningful even as moods and pleasures fluctuate.

In that sense, the goal is not to jump off the treadmill.

It is to learn **how to stand on it without letting it decide what life is for**.

And when that shift occurs, the wheel that once seemed exhausting becomes something else entirely: a movement within a larger life whose direction is no longer determined by the next fleeting reward.

Appendix A — Civilisational Response Matrix

The following matrix summarises the core patterns explored throughout the essay.

Each civilisation can be understood as a long-term cultural response to the same underlying discovery: **happiness fades and therefore cannot serve as the primary anchor of a life.**

The matrix highlights four elements:

- the **historical pressure or "wound"** that shaped the civilisation's worldview
- the **core mechanism** it developed in response

- the **positive strength** this mechanism produces
- the **shadow or distortion** that can appear when the mechanism is taken too far

Civilisation	Defining Pressure / Historical Wound	Core Mechanism	Positive Strength	Shadow
Mediterranean / Aristotelian	Political instability but rich civic culture	Flourishing through excellence, virtue, and community	Cultivation of mastery, beauty, friendship, and civic life	Fragile when stability collapses; assumes conditions that allow flourishing
Indian (Buddhist + Gita traditions)	Awareness of impermanence and cycles of suffering	Detachment from craving; action without attachment to results	Inner freedom, serenity, psychological clarity	Risk of withdrawal from worldly engagement
Northern European / Nietzschean	Harsh environments and erosion of inherited religious meaning	Creation of meaning through strength, will, and self-overcoming	Resilience, individuality, creative ambition	Isolation, existential pressure on the individual
Russian / Dostoevskian	Historical suffering, political upheaval, spiritual intensity	Suffering as a path toward moral and spiritual depth	Emotional depth, empathy, moral seriousness	Romanticising suffering; suspicion toward prosperity
East Asian / Confucian	Maintaining order in large, complex societies	Harmony through roles, ritual, and social responsibility	Social stability, dignity in duty, continuity across generations	Conformity; suppression of individuality
Jewish	Repeated exile, persecution, and cultural survival	Meaning through responsibility, law, and repairing the world	Intellectual vitality, resilience, ethical seriousness	Permanent urgency; difficulty resting in contentment
Islamic	Desire for moral and spiritual order under divine sovereignty	Orientation of life toward God and transcendent purpose	Unity of spiritual and everyday life; strong	Risk of fatalism; tension with secular modernity

Civilisation	Defining Pressure / Historical Wound	Core Mechanism	Positive Strength	Shadow
			communal identity	
Polynesian	Ecological interdependence in oceanic environments	Identity embedded in community and nature	Deep connection with nature and collective belonging	Vulnerable to external disruption; difficult to scale to modern states

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Reading the Matrix

This table does not claim that any civilisation is reducible to a single idea. Each contains internal diversity and centuries of evolution. The goal of the matrix is simply to highlight **the dominant pattern** that tends to appear when the tradition reflects on the instability of happiness.

Several patterns become visible when the traditions are viewed side by side.

Some responses emphasize **inner transformation** (Indian, Buddhist traditions).

Others emphasize **action in the world** (Mediterranean, Jewish).

Others emphasise **strength of the individual** (Northern European).

Others stabilise meaning through **social order** (Confucian).

Others through **spiritual transcendence** (Islamic).

Others through **moral depth in suffering** (Russian).

And some through **ecological belonging** (Polynesian).

Each strategy protects something valuable in human life. But each also leaves another dimension exposed.

The purpose of the matrix is therefore not to identify a “correct” civilisation but to reveal the remarkable range of human solutions to the same existential problem.

When happiness proves unstable, cultures do not give up on meaning.

They simply build it on different foundations.

Appendix B — Civilisational Pairwise Comparisons (Integrated Matrix)

The civilisational profiles in the main essay describe distinct strategies for living with the instability of happiness. When placed side by side, these strategies reveal patterns of **tension, complementarity, and philosophical contrast**.

The purpose of this appendix is not to judge which tradition is correct. Instead, it highlights how different civilisations respond to the same human problem from different angles. When their assumptions collide, the contrast often illuminates strengths and blind spots on both sides.

The comparisons below focus on the most instructive interactions among the traditions discussed in the essay.

Mediterranean / Aristotelian vs Other Traditions

Mediterranean vs Northern European

Flourishing vs endurance

The Mediterranean worldview centers on the cultivation of a balanced and flourishing life—mastery, friendship, beauty, and civic participation.

Northern European traditions often emphasize endurance and self-creation in a harsher world. Meaning must be forged through strength rather than discovered through balance.

The contrast reveals two interpretations of the good life:

one oriented toward **harmonious flourishing**, the other toward **resilient self-overcoming**.

Mediterranean vs Russian

Joy of life vs redemptive suffering

Mediterranean culture tends to treat life as something to be savored and cultivated.

Russian cultural traditions often emphasize suffering as a path toward moral and spiritual depth.

To Mediterranean sensibilities, the Russian fascination with suffering can appear heavy or tragic.

To Russian sensibilities, Mediterranean optimism can appear shallow or naïve.

The tension reflects different historical experiences with stability and catastrophe.

Mediterranean vs Jewish

Celebration vs responsibility

Mediterranean traditions emphasize the art of living well—friendship, conversation, pleasure, and beauty.

Jewish civilisation places stronger emphasis on ethical responsibility, historical memory, and the repair of the world.

Where the Mediterranean asks *How can we flourish?*

Jewish thought often asks *What obligations do we carry?*

The contrast illustrates the balance between **enjoying life** and **improving it**.

Mediterranean vs Indian

Cultivating life vs transcending desire

Mediterranean thought generally embraces worldly life and seeks to refine it through excellence.

Indian traditions often see worldly desire itself as the root of suffering and aim to transcend attachment to it.

The Mediterranean model deepens engagement with the world;

the Indian model loosens its psychological grip.

Mediterranean vs East Asian (Confucian)

Individual flourishing vs social harmony

Mediterranean traditions emphasize the flourishing of individuals within a community.

Confucian civilisation emphasizes the maintenance of harmonious roles within a structured social order.

Both value community, but the Mediterranean approach highlights **personal excellence**, while the Confucian model prioritizes **social stability**.

Mediterranean vs Islamic

Human flourishing vs divine orientation

Mediterranean philosophy often locates meaning within human capacities—reason, virtue, and civic life.

Islamic civilisation orients meaning toward God and divine order.

The contrast reflects different centers of gravity:

one grounded in **human flourishing**, the other in **spiritual submission**.

Mediterranean vs Polynesian

Cultivated civilisation vs ecological belonging

Mediterranean culture historically emphasizes cultivated civilisation—cities, institutions, and artistic development.

Polynesian traditions emphasize belonging within a living ecological network of land, sea, ancestors, and community.

The contrast reflects two different relationships with nature: shaping it versus living within it.

Northern European / Nietzschean vs Other Traditions

Northern European vs Russian

Self-created meaning vs spiritual suffering

Northern European philosophy, particularly in Nietzsche's work, treats meaning as something individuals must create through strength and self-overcoming.

Russian thought often views suffering as a gateway to spiritual depth rather than something to overcome through will.

Where Nietzsche proclaims **affirmation of life**, Russian literature often seeks **redemption through moral struggle**.

Northern European vs Jewish

Individual will vs collective responsibility

Northern European traditions emphasize the autonomy of the individual who creates meaning independently.

Jewish civilisation anchors meaning in shared law, communal responsibility, and historical continuity.

The contrast highlights two survival strategies:

standing alone versus standing together.

Northern European vs Indian

Affirmation vs detachment

Nietzschean thought affirms life—including its suffering—and encourages engagement with the world.

Indian traditions often pursue liberation through detachment from desire and the cycles of craving.

One celebrates the will to live intensely;

the other seeks freedom from the compulsions of desire.

Northern European vs Confucian

Radical individuality vs social harmony

Northern European philosophy often celebrates the individual who breaks with convention.

Confucian civilisation emphasizes the importance of fulfilling established social roles.

Where Nietzsche praises the individual who transcends norms, Confucian thought values the person who stabilizes society.

Northern European vs Islamic

Self-created meaning vs divine submission

Nietzschean philosophy asserts that meaning must be created by humans in a world where traditional religious certainties have weakened.

Islamic civilisation grounds meaning in submission to God.

The contrast illustrates two opposite responses to the question of authority:

human self-creation versus divine command.

Northern European vs Polynesian

Individual identity vs relational identity

Northern European traditions tend to treat identity as fundamentally individual.

Polynesian traditions often understand identity as relational—embedded within family, community, and the natural environment.

The contrast reflects two distinct understandings of the self.

Russian / Dostoevskian vs Other Traditions

Russian vs Jewish

Redemptive suffering vs ethical repair

Russian traditions often interpret suffering as spiritually meaningful.

Jewish civilisation focuses more strongly on confronting injustice and repairing the world.

One tradition deepens meaning through suffering itself;

the other seeks to transform the conditions that produce suffering.

Russian vs Indian

Suffering as meaning vs suffering as illusion

Indian traditions frequently interpret suffering as arising from attachment and ignorance.

Russian thought often treats suffering as morally and spiritually meaningful.

The Indian path seeks liberation from suffering;

the Russian path seeks truth through it.

Russian vs Confucian

Existential depth vs social order

Russian literature often explores extreme psychological and spiritual struggles.

Confucian civilisation prioritizes stability and harmony within society.

The Russian tradition dives into existential conflict;

the Confucian tradition attempts to prevent it.

Russian vs Islamic

Tragic faith vs ordered faith

Both traditions contain strong spiritual elements, but they emphasize different aspects of religious experience.

Russian spirituality often dwells in tension, doubt, and moral struggle.

Islamic civilisation emphasizes submission to divine order and the coherence of God’s will.

Russian vs Polynesian

Spiritual tragedy vs natural belonging

Russian thought often explores the tragic dimensions of existence.

Polynesian traditions emphasize harmony with nature and community.

The contrast illustrates two ways of situating the human being in the cosmos:

through existential struggle or ecological belonging.

Jewish vs Other Traditions

Jewish vs Indian

Repair the world vs transcend the world

Jewish civilisation encourages ethical engagement with history and society.

Indian traditions often pursue liberation from worldly cycles of desire.

One path emphasizes action within history;

the other seeks freedom beyond it.

Jewish vs Confucian

Covenantal responsibility vs social hierarchy

Jewish tradition organizes meaning around covenant, law, and ethical obligation.

Confucian civilisation structures meaning around hierarchical roles and social harmony.

Both emphasize duty but anchor it in different frameworks.

Jewish vs Islamic

Lawful covenant vs submission

Both traditions are strongly shaped by religious law.

Jewish civilisation emphasizes covenantal responsibility between God and a particular community.

Islamic civilisation emphasizes universal submission to God’s will.

Jewish vs Polynesian

Historical identity vs ecological belonging

Jewish identity is deeply tied to historical memory and textual tradition.

Polynesian identity is often rooted in land, ancestry, and ecological relationships.

Both offer strong communal identity but derive it from different sources.

East Asian / Confucian vs Other Traditions

Confucian vs Indian

Social order vs spiritual liberation

Confucian civilisation emphasizes harmony in social relationships.

Indian traditions often prioritize liberation from worldly cycles.

The former organizes life within society;

the latter often seeks freedom from its constraints.

Confucian vs Islamic

Ritual harmony vs divine law

Confucian traditions organize society through ritual and hierarchical roles.

Islamic civilisation structures life around divine law and submission to God.

Both produce ordered societies but draw authority from different sources.

Confucian vs Polynesian

Structured hierarchy vs organic community

Confucian society emphasizes carefully defined hierarchies.

Polynesian communities often emphasize relational belonging within ecological networks.

Both value community but structure it differently.

Islamic vs Polynesian

Transcendent order vs ecological belonging

Islamic civilisation grounds meaning in a transcendent divine order.

Polynesian traditions often ground meaning in the living world itself.

One points upward toward the divine;

the other outward toward the interconnectedness of nature.

Appendix D — Key Thinkers and Texts

The civilisational patterns described in this essay did not arise from a single author or moment in history. They are the result of long cultural developments expressed through religion, philosophy, literature, and social practice.

However, certain thinkers and texts capture the core intuitions of each tradition with particular clarity. The following list highlights some of the most influential sources through which these civilisational responses to the instability of happiness have been articulated.

The purpose is not to provide an exhaustive bibliography but to point toward **representative voices** that illuminate each worldview.

Mediterranean / Aristotelian

Key Thinkers

- Aristotle
- Plato
- Cicero

Key Texts

- *Nicomachean Ethics* — Aristotle
- *Politics* — Aristotle
- *The Republic* — Plato
- *On Duties* (*De Officiis*) — Cicero

Core Idea

Human flourishing arises through the cultivation of virtue and excellence within a well-ordered community.

Indian (Buddhist and Hindu Traditions)

Key Thinkers

- Siddhartha Gautama (the Buddha)
- Vyasa (traditionally associated with the *Bhagavad Gita*)
- Nagarjuna

Key Texts

- *The Dhammapada*
- *The Bhagavad Gita*
- *The Upanishads*
- *Mulamadhyamakakarika* — Nagarjuna

Core Idea

Suffering arises from attachment and craving; liberation comes through insight, disciplined action, and detachment from outcomes.

Northern European / Nietzschean

Key Thinkers

- Friedrich Nietzsche
- Søren Kierkegaard
- Martin Heidegger

Key Texts

- *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* — Nietzsche
- *Beyond Good and Evil* — Nietzsche
- *The Sickness Unto Death* — Kierkegaard
- *Being and Time* — Heidegger

Core Idea

In a world where traditional structures of meaning weaken, individuals must confront existential freedom and create meaning through their actions.

Russian / Dostoevskian

Key Thinkers

- Fyodor Dostoevsky
- Leo Tolstoy
- Nikolai Berdyaev

Key Texts

- *The Brothers Karamazov* — Dostoevsky
- *Crime and Punishment* — Dostoevsky
- *War and Peace* — Tolstoy
- *The Destiny of Man* — Berdyaev

Core Idea

Human suffering, when confronted honestly, can reveal moral and spiritual depth.

East Asian / Confucian

Key Thinkers

- Confucius
- Mencius
- Xunzi

Key Texts

- *The Analects* — Confucius
- *Mencius*
- *The Great Learning*
- *The Doctrine of the Mean*

Core Idea

Meaning emerges through the harmonious fulfillment of social roles within a stable moral order.

Jewish

Key Thinkers

- Moses (as the central figure of the Torah tradition)
- Maimonides
- Martin Buber

Key Texts

- *The Torah* (Hebrew Bible)
- *Guide for the Perplexed* — Maimonides
- *I and Thou* — Martin Buber

Core Idea

Human life is structured through covenant, ethical responsibility, and the ongoing effort to repair the world.

Islamic

Key Thinkers

- The Prophet Muhammad

- Al-Ghazali
- Ibn Sina (Avicenna)
- Ibn Khaldun

Key Texts

- *The Qur'an*
- *The Revival of the Religious Sciences* — Al-Ghazali
- *The Book of Healing* — Ibn Sina
- *The Muqaddimah* — Ibn Khaldun

Core Idea

Human life gains meaning through submission to divine will and alignment with a transcendent moral order.

Polynesian

Unlike many philosophical traditions, Polynesian worldviews were primarily transmitted through **oral tradition** rather than formal philosophical texts.

Key Sources

- Creation chants and genealogical traditions
- Navigational knowledge systems
- Oral histories and mythological cycles

Representative Themes

- the sacred relationship between land, sea, and ancestors
- communal identity and kinship
- ecological balance

Core Idea

Human identity is embedded within a living network that includes community, ancestors, and the natural world.

Appendix D. A Three-Axis Model of Civilisational Strategies

The diversity of civilisational philosophies can be understood as different ways of stabilising three fundamental psychological variables: **desire**, **authority**, and **identity**.

The hedonic treadmill destabilises life because human beings continuously want more, interpret meaning through shifting frameworks, and experience themselves as agents

pursuing satisfaction. Civilisations therefore develop cultural systems that “lock” one or more of these variables into stable configurations.

Three axes capture these stabilising strategies.

1. Desire
Civilisations differ in how they handle human wanting. Some traditions attempt to *reduce or detach from desire*, arguing that craving itself generates suffering. Others *intensify or redirect desire* toward excellence, achievement, or transcendence.

2. Authority of Meaning
Cultures also differ in where meaning is anchored. Some locate it in **external structures** such as divine law, social order, or cosmological frameworks. Others place responsibility for meaning within the **individual will**.

3. Identity
Finally, civilisations vary in how they define the self. In some traditions the individual is **embedded** within lineage, community, or ecology. In others the individual appears as a largely **autonomous agent**, responsible for creating purpose and direction.

Different civilisations stabilise different combinations of these variables. The resulting philosophies appear diverse, but each represents a coherent response to the same underlying problem: how to organise life when pleasure is unstable.

Civilisation	Desire Strategy	Authority of Meaning	Identity Structure	Cultural Expression
Mediterranean	Intensify through excellence	Mixed (virtue within shared norms)	Moderately individual	Human flourishing through mastery and cultivation
Indian	Reduce or detach from desire	Metaphysical/cosmic order	Inward but less individualised	Liberation through detachment and disciplined action
Northern European	Intensify through individual will	Individual creation of meaning	Strongly individual	Affirm life through action and self-created values
East Asian	Moderate desire through discipline	External social order	Embedded relational self	Harmony through roles, ritual, and hierarchy

Civilisation	Desire Strategy	Authority of Meaning	Identity Structure	Cultural Expression
Jewish	Moderate desire through obligation	External moral law	Communal but portable identity	Meaning through responsibility, law, and repair
Islamic	Redirect desire toward transcendence	Divine authority	Communal spiritual identity	Desire fulfilled through devotion to God
Polynesian	Dissolve the individual subject of desire	Ecological and ancestral order	Fully embedded identity	Belonging within lineage, land, and sea